

> **India will identify, trace and punish every terrorist and their backers. We'll pursue them to the ends of the earth. They will be punished beyond their imagination"**
>
> **PM NARENDRA MODI**
> *at a public rally in Madhubani, Bihar*

suspension will not disrupt the current flow of water to Pakistan, any future unilateral steps by India, like building canals or dams to divert the water for its own use, could seriously affect the lower riparian regions downstream in Pakistan. Islamabad has already called India's action tantamount to an "act of war". One disadvantage for India is that while Pakistan's demand for Kashmir has so far been on religious grounds, any threat to its water supply could shift popular opinion in the country in favour of war over Kashmir. Meanwhile, Pakistan also restricted Indian access to its air space, and suspended the Simla Agreement of 1972 as well.

In addition to the IWT suspension, the CCS announced a series of other diplomatic sanctions, including the closure of the border check-post at Attari in Amritsar, the expulsion of defence attaches and their senior advisors in the Pakistani High Commission in Delhi, and the revocation of SAARC visas issued to Pakistani citizens. It also made it clear that more punitive measures would follow. At a public rally on April 24 in Madhubani in Bihar, the PM himself sent out a message intended for the world. Switching to English midway through his Hindi speech, he declared, "Today, from the soil of Bihar, I say to the whole world, India will identify, trace and punish every terrorist and their backers. We will pursue them to the ends of the Earth. They will be punished beyond their imagination."

Modi is sending out a clear signal to Pakistan that India will not hesitate to explore all options, including military force, to punish it for crossing a dangerous red line. Kanwal Sibal, former foreign secretary, believes that by choosing to suspend the IWT over exercising military power as in the past, India has sent out a powerful message that it is going to hit where it hurts. At the same time, Sibal reasons, "It is a wrong time geopolitically and otherwise for India to get into a military conflict with Pakistan. We can talk about it to satisfy our emotions, but just when our growth story is becoming more credible, we will get deflected. We have also held that this is not an era for war, and dialogue and diplomacy are the way out. So, we would lose our credibility internationally." Sibal notes that while India has viable military options, suspending the IWT will be more effective because water or the lack of it is a significant issue for Pakistan. "It's a strategic blow to Pakistan."

Others argue that punitive measures that have a slow burn, such as suspending the IWT, will not satisfy the Indian public,



> **Kashmir was our jugular vein, it will be our jugular vein, we will not forget it. We will not leave our Kashmiri brothers in their heroic struggle"**
>
> **GEN. ASIM MUNIR**
> *Chief of Pakistan army*